

Social Media Diet Content & Body Image Among Young Egyptian Females



The influence of social media diet content on body perception and eating disorders
among young Egyptian females - **(G5A)**

Galala University

LIB116: Research and Analytical Skills

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Author Note

This research project, *The Influence of Social Media Diet Content on Body Perception and Eating Disorders Among Young Egyptian Females*, is being conducted as part of the LIB116: Research and Analytical Skills course at Galala University.

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Abstract

The present research focuses on the effects of social media on the body image and self-attitude of young Egyptian females in the age group **18-25 years**. Results also indicate that **75.5%** often consumes diet content **via TikTok and Instagram**. **56.5%** often accept workout challenges with **39.5%** often accepting weight loss tips with **47.5%** spending more than **six hours** on social media daily. However, **43%** of respondents said they felt pressured to look better, while **40%** looks for specific body sizes. Apart from looks, **41 %** revealed developing adverse mental health, and **34 %** recommended changing eating habits. Nonetheless, cultural beauty norms prevailed; however, **38.7 %** were of neutral opinion and emphasized on availability and access to global media exposure and its influence on the perception of body image. This cured content promotes body dissatisfaction, social comparison, low self-esteem, worsens mental health and eating disorders. The work stresses the important and timely necessity of media literacy practices and body positivity and/or effects of social media workshops and strong partnerships with successful influencers who can help the young women establish realistic and achievable beauty standards and maintain their mental and psychological well-being in the increasingly competitive digital world.

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*Keywords: Social media, Body image, Mental health, Eating disorders,
Young Egyptian women, Body dissatisfaction, social comparison*

**The influence of social media diet content on body perception and
eating disorders among young Egyptian females**

Social networks have entered the lives of many people and changed the ways of interaction, the ways of sharing the experience and the perception of themselves. Young females, especially Egyptian, are affected as the two platforms mentioned, Tik Tok and Instagram, are flooded with content concerning diets and beauty. This content tends to perpetrate unrealistic role models of slimes and fitness which in the long run affect the self-image and psychological well-being of the users. Young Egyptian females who are in conflict between their tradition and the western culture beauty standards receive more and more curated, filtered and the best images, which can cause negative body image for them as outcome of social comparison.

Young Egyptian women between the age of 18 to 25 years are the target group for this study due to factors such as developmental age, high usage of social media platforms, and sensitivity to social and peer pressure. It explores their trends of social media use, what kind of diet and beauty content they interact with most often, and how the material affects their body image, mental health, and eating. Special attention is paid to the role of social media in increasing social comparison

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processes, amplifying threats, and increasing rates of anxiety and depressive syndrome using theoretical concepts including Social Comparison Theory. The study also looks at a range of sociocultural factors to analyze how gender roles, economic inequalities and opportunities to get professional help affect the use of social networks in this segment.

In this study, quantitative surveys will be integrated to offer a comprehensive analysis of the context in which social media is used. On the one hand, it provides a chance to address body positivity, inclusivity, and mental health; on the other, it is used to promote negative attitudes that harm self-esteem and mental health. The study also considers general conclusions regarding these dynamics, and provides guidelines for further interventions, including media literacy, body positivity sessions and mental health care. Hence, this study aims at establishing strategies by examining significant trends and challenges that will help young Egyptian women to develop a sound relationship with their body and the content they take on social media to enhance resilience to social pressures and embrace good mental health in the future.

Literature Review

Over the past few years, Self-promotion and the use of social media in that context, has been a major issue of debate with regards to body image regardless of the gender but focusing on young women in Egypt. Given that young females are exposed to diet content and fitness idealized media images on the World Wide Web, they are bound to get a raw deal in terms of the type of messages received about thinness and beauty standards, most of which are impossible to attain. Such a digital influence is most possibly influential to young women and adolescent girls since they can be influenced to conform to such values. Research findings reveal that constant receipt of these messages may lead to negative pathways to body image, self-esteem, and eating disorders, and that through emulation of the images viewed online, young women pursue (Taha et al., 2018)

The increased use of social media has therefore altered the portrayal of womanhood among young women. In Egypt where there are culturally ordered expectations in regard to issues of beauty and body image, social media is a new dimension that shapes how young Egyptian women think and regard issues to do with bodies and worth. Several studies have supported such findings, hence the emergence of (Raggatt et al., 2018; Sanzari et al., 2023). Most social networks help young women get acquainted with sexualized images of beautiful thinness that are promoted through selfies that have been retouched and polished. Research has

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revealed that it is a kind of exposure that affects young women much to the extreme since it adds on the cultural pressure that is already placed on females, resulting into such sequelae like being negative to the bodies, low self-esteem, and tendency to eating disorders. Rather, these studies demonstrated that 35.4% of Egyptian young women are at a high risk of developing eating disorders and that 28.8% of the same sample has already a negative body image.

The studies show that social media plays a positive and a negative role in body image. While some of the young women find the body positive communities on the platforms helpful, many of them go through this cycle of social comparison that produce body dissatisfaction and poor mental health (Merino et al., 2024). Such injury is caused by frequent confrontation to thin and beautiful images in mass media that young women with body image internalization tendencies are constantly exposed to. This is a tendency which is encouraged by influencers and contents known as ‘fitspiration,’ meaning women, especially the young ones, chase nearly unattainable body goals in what seems like a vicious cycle. Besides, the above dependents have become closely associated with several psychological disorders such as anxiety and depression (Jiotsa et al., 2021). It all only gets worse with the recent discourse of “toxic positivity” on social media platforms which encourages its users to ignore difficulty in favor of positivity, it makes it even harder for young

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women to seek help concerning body image problems or eating disorders. (Diab & Wang, 2023).

These are the sociocultural and the social economic factors that come in Integration as Added. Young women are affected by body image due to cultural well-being standards of the Egyptian society, conventional gender roles, as well as low access to mental health services. As highlighted by Goda et al., (2024 as well as Abu-Elenin et al., 2019). Although there is a lot of oral and written information discussing on the importance of the SES in gaining access to mental health support and information, body positivity and knowledge, literature research put forth that young females are vulnerable to the negative effects of social media (Taha et al., 2018). For instance, since the above-mentioned group of females lacks access to support systems and education regarding the media, they will present themselves to buy into the ugly standards of beauty that will affect them both, physically and psychologically.

This study endeavors to explain how social media influences body satisfaction, eating behavior, and mental health among young Egyptian women. Social media platforms, while offering opportunities for positive engagement and body positivity, more often foster unrealistic body ideals, leading to increased body dissatisfaction, eating disorders, and other mental health concerns. This study will investigate both the constructive and adverse aspects of social media, focusing on

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how social comparisons impact young women's self-perception, the specific influence of content types related to fitness and dieting, and the broader sociocultural and socioeconomic factors shaping body image in this demographic. It will also extend its findings on how social media affect body image and mental health in young Egyptian women. It therefore offers effective practice recommendations for educational and therapeutic actions to effect change in this group of women in matters concerning their mental health and self-esteem. Policymakers and educators may also use this work to create other materials that would help in increasing consciousness about positive body image and mental health among people.

This paper aims to illustrate the role of social media in determining the body satisfaction, eating habits, and mental health of young Egyptian females. While social media can be used to promote pro-ED individuals' self-acceptance and body positivity, it primarily promotes the goals of producing thin ideal images that are likely to cause body dissatisfaction, eating disorders and other health issues. In examination of the probabilities and threats of social media, it will examine how social comparison influences body image among young women; the effects of fitness and diet contents; sociocultural and socioeconomic factors.

1-Social Media as a Double-Edged Sword

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Research has also found that social media plays a complex role in influencing the perception of body image, and in most cases, create positive messages but also negative ones. On one hand, social media offers supportive environments from body-positive organizations, it also constantly reminds an individual of beauty standards. Focus group interviews conducted by Boutros et al. (2024) to college students exposed that one's body image can be acted on by social media in good as well as in bad spirits. One participant mentioned that while at times they were able to find support for their body positivity, they found loads of shameful pictures. This conflict raises awareness of the relation between the embodiment and social networks' use, suggesting that experiences might vary significantly depending on social and individual factors.

Merino et al. (2024) supported these conclusions by conducting a systematic literature review and observing that social networking sites most of the time convey thin ideal adverts that are unhealthy for women. This is particularly worrying because these slots are used by teenagers and young adults, who are in the processes of role transformation. The desire for the development of such research has been highlighted because of understanding the manner, in which digital spaces reinforce cultural and social standards of beauty since such effects may greatly affect mental health.

2-Vulnerability to Body Dissatisfaction

The prevalence of social media-related body image dissatisfaction is higher or lower in different groups of people at different times. In their systematic review of the psychological mechanisms involved in relation between social media and body image, (Diab and Wang. 2023) pointed out the role of peer comparison and social pressure. Their study revealed that young women in particular, can develop a negative view of themselves because of the ideal body images they are daily exposed to. This condition leads to a negative cycle of self-evaluation, which gets worse when one lobbies for acceptance of oneself by the society and the resulting anxiety that stems from evaluation based simply on looks.

(Jiotsa et al. 2021) also studied the process of social comparison in social networks and showed that dynamic comparison can lead too improper nutrition and increased desire for a perfect body. The cases of social media use and the habit of paying more attention to the looks of other people and identifying with the images shown. This works hand in hand with (Festinger's (1954)) social comparison theory, it states that people tend to compare themselves with others in order to establish the truth regarding their worth. This theory provides some way of understanding how interface with such images on social networking websites may interfere with the ways in which a person constructs his or her identity and, in the process, cause some harm.

3-The Impact of Content Type on Body Image

The content consumption through social media is directly influencing an individual's body image and eating habits. Using a similar study, (Raggatt et al. (2018)) examined how the presence of fits spirituality affected the body images of users who came across the content. While some participants stated that such content motivated them others note the content makes them feel more inadequate and insecure about their bodies. This shows different facet of fitspiration; although it encourages inspiration, it negatively impacts if the users feel they are inadequate or want from the images being promoted.

Building upon this, Rounsefell et al. (2020)) extended this discussion by categorizing some types of fitspiration material and assessing how they elicit varying shifts in health-related beliefs and behaviors. They then found out that this kind of content, particularly one urging viewer to engage in sever exercise regimes and strictly followed diets, had extremely negative impacts as it meant that views continued to embrace unrealistic body images and developed eating disorders patterns. It reveals a young population that should be educated on the types of messages they learn from a particular media, dieting and fitness in particular, and which ones are negative as opposed to what can be positive for them.

To add more details about the relationship between content type and impact on body image disturbances, (Sanzari et al. (2023)) did more research.

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From their study, the authors concluded that subjects who viewed weight loss content liked it a lot and had a low body image. Based on the study, it was also established that social media content has a more profound impact on the body image results than the quantity of the time spent online. This underlines the necessity to develop the concept of how content has to be shared and consumed in social networks.

4-The Interplay of Mental Health and Emotional Factors

Between social media, mental health, and body image, relationships are intricate and multifaceted. As noted by Malloy et al. (2024) trust in social media concerning body image does not necessarily coincide with the quality of the chosen diet. Instead, they stressed such cognitive-affective aspects as stress, anxiety, or sadness in relation to the formation of YW's eating behavior. This means that moderators relating to mental health play a central role in how social media affects eating disorders and body image.

Toxic positivity in social media sites further enriches the user's emotional landscape, or rather, distorts it in the negative way. It allowed people to suppress their incompetent feelings due to toxic positivity which is the rejection of negative experience and emotions in favor of positive outlook. Eating disorders

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among women may be hard to prevent or treat because of this power struggle that exists in relationships and may heighten feelings of shame or isolation.

Apart from body image, social media has a worrying impact on mental health. For example, Hatata et al. (2009) reported that, low body image satisfaction among teenagers in Egypt was at 28.8% that could in turn cause anxiety and depression. This means there is need to come up with strategies dealing with mental health as well as the usage of social media.

5- Prevalence and Contributing Factors

Many factors have been attributed to the rising incidences of eating disorders among young Egyptian females. Based on (Mohamed et al., 2024), the findings showed that the percentage of bulimia nervosa among young Egyptians was 13.3% and the behaviors related to the disorder was evaluated based on; anxiety, BMI and social support. Gender also comes into play here, in that gender roles and expectations that are propagated in cultures are major predictors to eating disorders among youthful female persons. The same observation was made by Fawzi et al. (2010) who establish that the prevalence of ED was much higher in the rural setting, hence it can be envisaged that sociodemographic differences could play a role in the development of disordered eating.

Such a pattern raises concerns on the impact which cultural factors have on young women and their body image perceptions. For example, Essa et al. (2020) established that females consuming more calories than necessary was the most prevalent among female university students and found that more than a third of the females were at risk of eating disorders. Their findings reveal how crucial it is to count dieting trends and cultural influences in the determination of eating disorders based on awareness during the prevention processes.

6-Clinical and Educational Implications

These trends have significant implications for therapy and education in particular. Malak, I., Saleh, H., Wilfley, D., & Laban, M. B. (2020) assessed the rate of eating disorder risk among the medical students at Tanta University and found high level of the risk of consumption of these disorders. From their findings, they agree with other researchers that eating problems in medical populations need to be diagnosed and treated more effectively. This has a need for implementing cultural competency in the proactive training of health care professionals the better to deal with these questions. Likewise, (Goda et al. (2024)) wanted to assess the efficiency of a curriculum for treating eating disorders among

female students in Assiut City. They concluded that an educational approach should be required for minimizing the impact of eating disorders to this population.

7-Implications for Interventions and Future Research

Thus, as a continuity of the presented work, the emphasis is placed on possible interventions that might help to minimize negative effects of social media regarding eating disorders and body image, including body positivity, media literacy, and mental health support. Those affect education and they can easily identify programs that instill coping mechanisms against conformity to societal norms regarding body image in young women and enable them to adopt healthy attitudes towards their bodies. Education for resistance against social pressures concerning body images should be enhanced, as programs allow youth positively to engage with social media information. In addition, there are programs which encourage diversity and acceptance of the body shape, which, in turn, can mitigate the effects of such beauty standards.

Further research should also consider what the impact of social media usage would be on the future eating behavior and body image in several samples. From analyzing how various groups of people respond to social media content, it will be easier to identify how best to create an environment that allows for customizing treatments and other resources that are appealing to such groups of

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people. Quantitative research may also provide more insight into the psychological processes as qualitative research that explores individual's social media experiences in more detail.

Finally, the social factors remain to largely be influential. For instance, Taha et al. (2018) concluded that while analyzing female's universities student in Taif Saudi Arabia there is a high prevalence of disordered eating behavior influenced by media pressure and thinness standard. Along the same line, (Abu-Elenin et al (2019) found that 35.5% of Egyptian teenage girls had disordered eating, which was associated with factors including low maternal employment, and parental education. These findings underscore the importance of the sociocultural and socioeconomic contexts within which EDs, and body image are explored, for the development of defined interference and operational approaches that can be rendered within a public health perspective.

In conclusion, it is possible to state that the analysis of the literature proves the fact that body image and mental health issues are greatly influenced by the presence of social media among young Egyptian women, and it escalates their dissatisfaction and propensity to eating disorders. While some of the content has positive aspects of body positivity there are severe limiting factors that affect the desired change within society regarding beauty standards. Issues such as these are

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compounded by cultural beliefs and economic status; for that reason, this is an area that requires more investigation as to the specific effects of localized cultural factors. Further investigation should be carried out into the intensity with which traditional values combine with western beauty standards ideals, and the impact of such programs on media analysis on such issues.

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Problem Statement, Diet content and unrealistic body image causes the most harm to young Egyptian women where social media platforms only amplifies it. This work shows that 35.4% of the respondents as well as those with a higher BMI are at risk of developing eating disorders and 28.8% of the respondents admitted to having a negative body image. It amplifies this dissatisfaction with the fitness and dieting influences, which generate feelings of unworthiness. These perceptions are aggravated by social media algorithms and many psychologists associate an increase in eating disorders with low mental and nutritional literacy. Body dissatisfaction in young Egyptian women is not debatable; social comparison and media exposure by Tiggemann and Slater (2014) and Fitzsimmons-Craft et al. (2016) proved negative affiliations with anxiety, depression and body image. This research seeks to address these challenges with Social Media Literacy, Digital Detox, Creative Art and Self-esteem lore for students in schools.

Research Objectives:

1. Objective 1: On this background, the study aims to explore how social media affects body perceptions amongst young Egyptian females to consider various contents which may trigger body dissatisfaction and social compares, how cultural pressure works, and potentialities to emphasize body positivism.

Sub-Objectives:

- Analyze the influence of idealized and manipulated images on self-esteem and body satisfaction.
- The role of influencers within such promotion of the beauty and fitness standards and its impact on young women.

2. Objective 2: In order to compare the results between social comparison, body image dissatisfaction, and self-reported mental health status among young Egyptian women.

Sub-Objectives:

- To determine how social media promotes social comparison regarding body satisfaction.
- To measure mental health consequences of social comparisons-anxiety and depressive symptoms-arising in young women.

3. Objective 3: The sociocultural and socioeconomic aspects related to the effects of social media in body image shall be described: limitation to mental health care.

Sub-Objectives:

- To explore how Egyptian cultural standards and gender expectations are related to body image perceptions.
- To explore socio-economic status as a pertinent variable in mediating access to resources that cultivate a healthy body image and a sense of the mental health problem.

Research Questions:

- o How does social comparison help account for the relationship between social media use and anxiety and depressive symptoms among Egyptian young women?
- o How does social media facilitate social comparison to bodies standards of satisfaction among young Egyptian women?
- o To what extent does exposure to edited images on social media affect the eating attitudes and behaviors of young Egyptian women?

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- In what ways does social comparison within social networking sites affect body image dissatisfaction among young Egyptian women?
- To what extent is body image dissatisfaction generated by social comparison associated with anxiety or depressive symptoms in young women?
- How does Egyptian culture and role of women in Egyptian society influence their beliefs about body image among males and females?
- To what extent is accessibility of sources, which will support positive Body Image influenced by the Socio-economic status in Egyptian society?
- Where are the socioeconomic and culturally sanctioned impediments within Egyptian society most preventable for mental health services among groups affected by body image issues, and how does it vary?

Methodology:

- **Deductive Approach:**
 - We are testing existing theories and relationships (e.g., social comparison theory) to confirm them with our data.
 - We are working with research questions and potentially hypotheses already derived from existing literature.
- **Using theory-based hypotheses and research questions:**
 - *Example Hypothesis:* “A study, that investigates the effect of social networking sites, especially the contents related to diet,

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confirmed that body dissatisfaction is more evident among young women.”

- **Example Research Question:**” What kind of post on social media platforms leads to body image dissatisfaction?”
- Using **Social Comparison Theory** and **Cultivation Theory** as the bases for our consideration. Moreover, other studies were conducted by authors Jiakun Wang in 2023 and Klein in 2013, Boutros et al. in 2024, and Sanzari et al. in 2023.

- **Primary Research:**

- We need fresh, firsthand data from young Egyptian females to address our objectives.
- Using surveys to gather data on their social media use, body image perceptions, and mental health.

- **Quantitative Approach:**

- The research proposition of the present work follows a quantitative paradigm, therefore centering around the variable of quantifiable characteristics of popular social media platforms, levels of dissatisfaction, and facets of mental health. This method allows systematic assessment of the interaction of these variables.
- The collection **of data** is done through surveys and to measure, participants responses and behaviors are made to correspond to **the Likert scale** factors.

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- **Population:**

- The study focuses on young Egyptian females aged between **18 and 25 years** because this group uses social media frequently and will be affected by such curated content on body image and mental health.

- **Sample:**

- ***Non-probability*** sampling is a type of open sampling technique is used to narrow the study down to participants who have an active social media presence. In terms of generating valid statistical significance, the minimum number of participants is set at 100 due to survey data collection.

Tools:

- Using Google Forms to create a survey:
<https://forms.gle/A8WXuNtsFB82Rcd97>

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Results

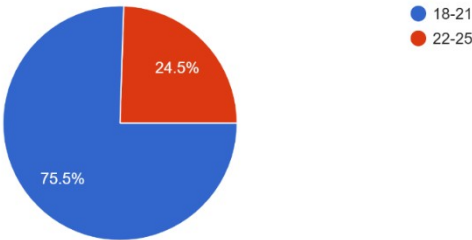
Table 1

1. Demographics and Platform Usage

Category	Subcategory	Percentage	Count
Age Group	18–21	75.5%	151
	22–25	24.5%	49
Social Media Usage	TikTok	64.5%	129
	Instagram	37%	74
	Facebook	33.5%	67
	Snapchat	29.5%	59

Figure 1: Age Group Distribution

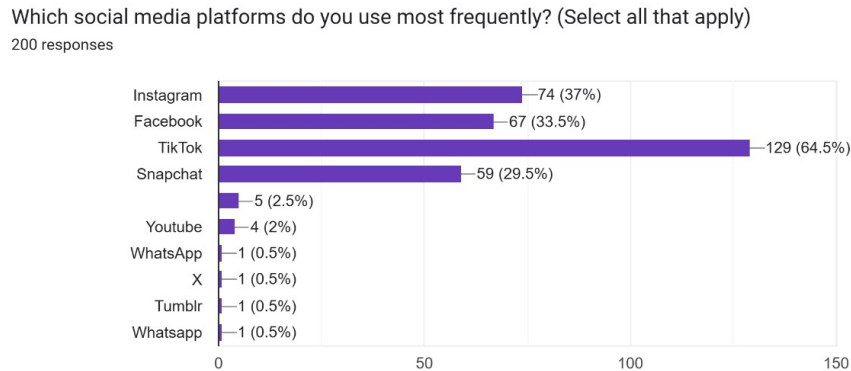
If you're between the age 18 and 25, please click your age and continue.
200 responses



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The age distribution of participants can be described as follows: **75.5%** of participants are aged between **18–21**, the other **24.5%** of the participants is aged between **22–25**.

Figure 2: Platform Usage



The most frequently mentioned platform is **TikTok (64.5%)**, followed by **Instagram (37%)**, **Facebook (33.5%)** and **Snapchat (29.5%)**. Thus, the data show that TikTok has the greatest impact on the respondents' decisions of which age.

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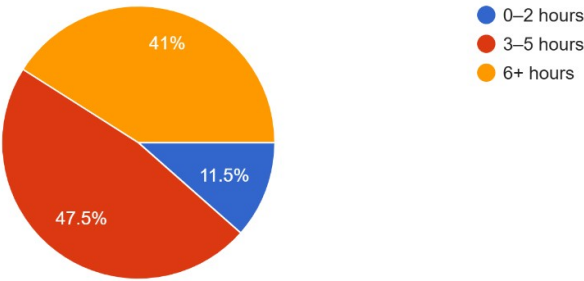
Table 2

2. Social Media Engagement and Time Spent

Category	Subcategory	Percentage	Count
Daily Social Media Usage	0–2 hours	11.5%	23
	3–5 hours	41%	95
	6+ hours	47.5%	82
Engagement with Content	Always	11%	22
	Often	19%	44
	Sometimes	42.5%	85

Figure 3: Daily Social Media Usage

How many hours a day do you spend on social media?
200 responses

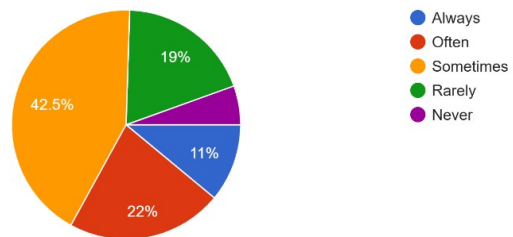


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The participants spend more time; **47.5%** of the participants spend **6 or more hours** in the day on social media **41%** spend **3-5 hours** on social media **11.5%** spend **0- 2 hours** on social media.

Figure 4: Engagement with Content

How often do you actively engage with social media content (e.g., likes, comments, shares)?
200 responses



42.5% of participants sometimes engage with social media content, **19%** often engage, **11%** always, meaning also that interaction is not constant.

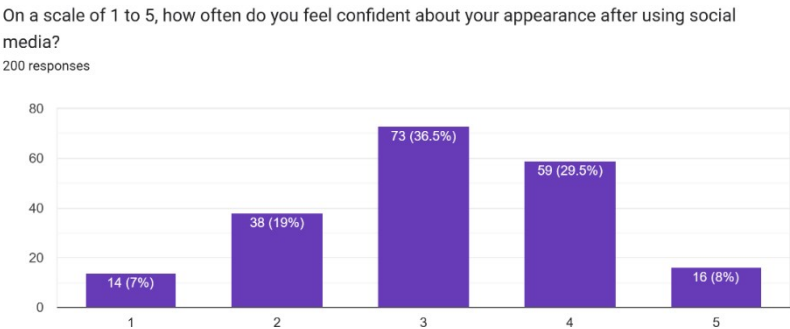
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Table 3

3. Impact on Mental Health and Body Image

Category	Subcategory	Percentage	Count
Body Image Confidence Post-social media	Very Confident	8%	16
	Neutral	36.5%	73
	Not Confident	19%	38
Body Comparison with Influencers	Always	7.5%	15
	Sometimes	38%	76
	Rarely	24.5%	49

Figure 5: Body Image Confidence

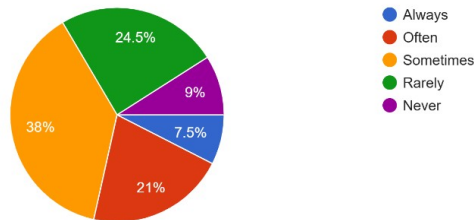


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Only **8%** of participants feel very confident about their body image after using social media, while **36.5%** feel neutral and **19%** report feeling not confident, indicating that social media negatively impacts confidence levels for some users.

Figure 6: Body comparison with Influencers

How often do you compare your physical appearance to influencers or celebrities on social media?
200 responses



A notable **38%** of participants sometimes compare themselves to influencers on social media, while **7.5%** always do so, and **24.5%** rarely compare themselves, highlighting social media's influence on body image perception.

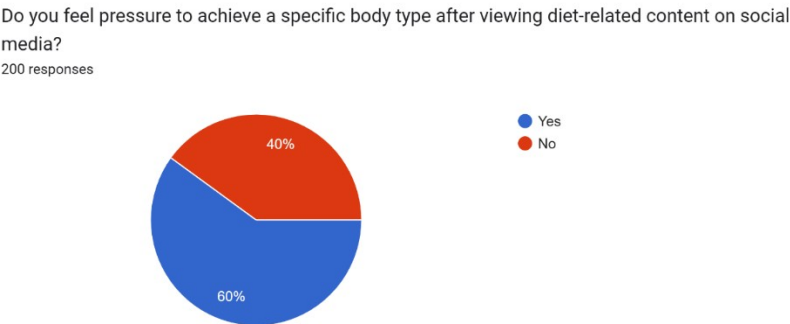
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Table 4

4. Behavior Changes and Pressures

Category	Subcategory	Percentage	Count
Pressure to Achieve Specific Body Type	Yes	40%	120
	No	60%	80
Change in Eating Habits Due to Content	Yes	34%	132
	No	66%	68

Figure 7: Pressure to Achieve Specific Body Type

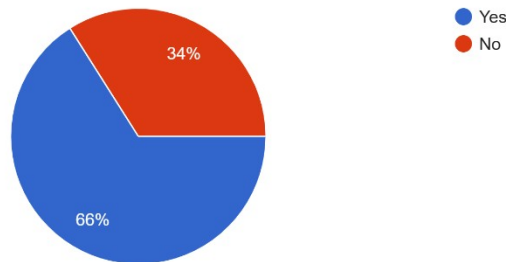


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40% of participants feel pressured to achieve a specific body type, while **60%** do not, suggesting a notable societal influence on body expectations.

Figure 8: Change in Eating Habits

Have you ever considered changing your eating habits or starting a diet because of social media content?
200 responses



34% of participants have changed their eating habits due to social media content, while **66%** have not, indicating that social media impacts eating behavior for a significant minority.

Conclusion

The study also highlights the dual nature of social media with regard to body perception development and mental health in young Egyptian women: on the one hand, it has a solid community of people who foster a healthy perception of the body; on the other hand, it is an instrument for advertising unrealistic appearance standards that contributed to increased body dissatisfaction, disordered eating, decreased mental health. These have been complemented by cultures that prescribe beauty, socio economic status and availability of mental health.

These suggest the urgent necessity of specific measures which would alleviate these negative repercussions. It will pay to work on such things as media literacy, body positivity, and mental health care to ensure this demographic has a much healthier understanding of themselves. Perhaps concerted efforts by educators' policymakers and social media influencers can lead to nurturing an environment that fights against the unattainable beauty standards thus empowering young women to embrace their individuality.

Another limitation to the findings of this study is the fact that there is long term effects of SNS use on body image and mental health have not yet been established in future studies especially in the cultural interface where traditional culture meets technology. This will create a foundation that enhances the

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development of improved strategies in the fight against damaging impact associated with social media on body image and mental health, particularly for people in Egypt.

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